

Marmosa murina

Common mouse opossum



Location N., C., and E. South America

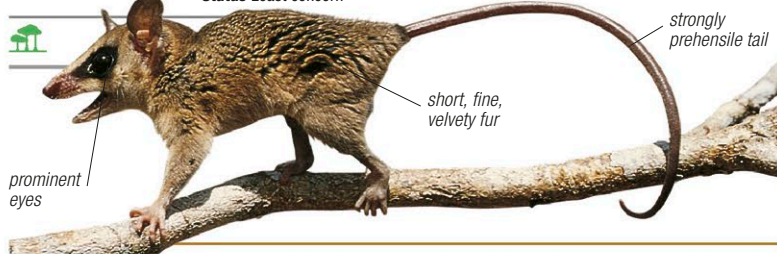
Length $4\frac{1}{4}$ – $5\frac{3}{4}$ in (11–14.5 cm)

Tail $5\frac{1}{4}$ – $8\frac{1}{2}$ in (13.5–21 cm)

Weight $\frac{7}{16}$ – $1\frac{1}{4}$ oz (15–45 g)

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern

*Chironectes minimus*

Water opossum



Location S. Mexico to C. South America

Length 10–16 in (26–40 cm)

Tail 12–17 in (31–43 cm)

Weight 20–29 oz (550–800 g)

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



Also called the yapok, this is the only aquatic marsupial. It has fine, dense, water-repellent

white-tipped tail

fur, long, webbed toes on its rear feet, and—in both male and female—a pouch with a muscular opening that can close tight underwater. The diet includes fish, frogs, and similar freshwater prey, detected and grabbed by the dextrous, clawless front toes. It rests by day in a leaf-lined river-bank den.

*Caluromysiops irrupta*

Black-shouldered opossum



Location W. South America

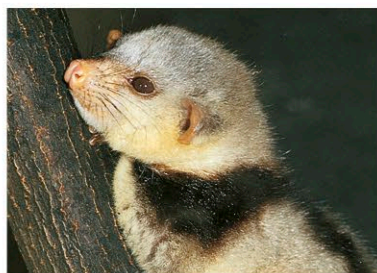
Length 10–13 in (25–33 cm)

Tail 9–12 in (22–31 cm)

Weight 7–21 oz (200–600 g)

Social unit Variable

Status Least concern



A broad, black stripe from shoulders to front legs distinguishes this woolly furred opossum. It forages by night in trees for a wide diet, including fruits and grubs. Its densely furred tail is gray, turning white at the end, with a hairless underside. Gestation is 13–14 days and the litter size is 2.

Neophascogale lorentzii

Long-clawed marsupial mouse



Location New Guinea

Length $6\frac{1}{2}$ –9 in (16–23 cm)

Tail $6\frac{1}{2}$ –9 in (17–22 cm)

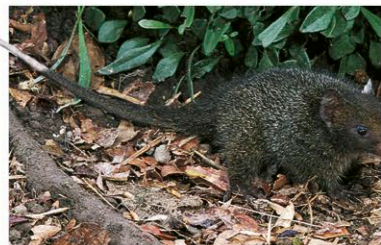
Weight 7–9 oz (200–250 g)

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



Also called the speckled dasyure because of the sprinkling of long, white hairs in the dark gray upper fur, this species has short, powerful limbs with very long claws on all toes. It digs by day for grubs, worms, and similar prey. Information on nesting and breeding is very sparse; 4 young have been recorded in the female's pouch.

*Didelphis virginiana*

Virginia opossum



Location W., C., and E. USA, Mexico, Central America

Length 13–20 in (33–50 cm)

Tail 10–21½ in (25–54 cm)

Weight 1–13 lb (0.5–6 kg)

Social unit Individual

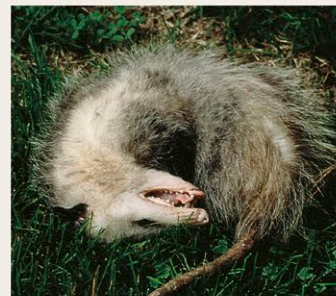
Status Least concern



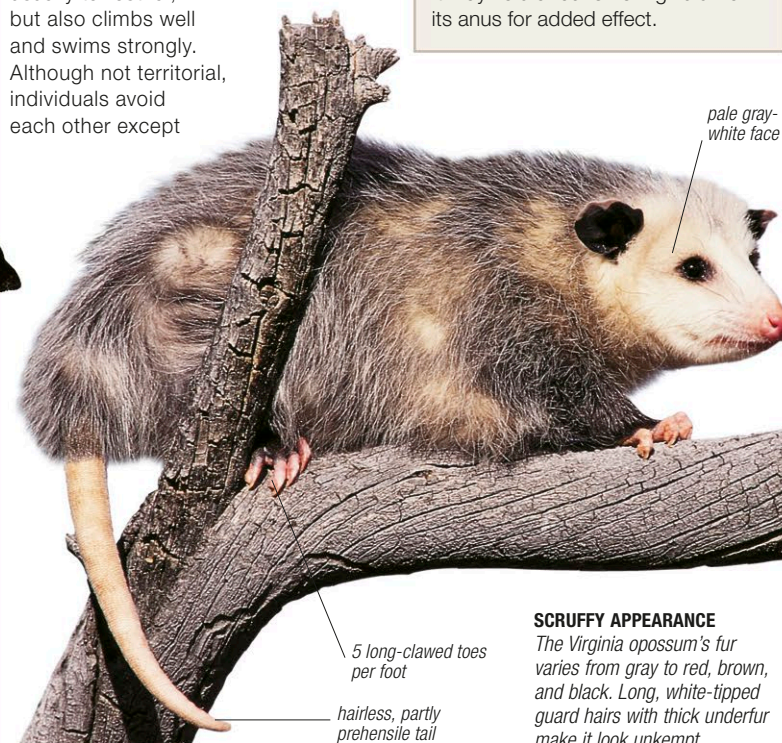
The highly adaptable Virginia opossum is actively expanding its range in North America. It benefits from human habitation, both for shelter because it nests in piles of debris or outbuildings, and for food because it scavenges for scraps. A true omnivore, its diet ranges from grubs and eggs to flowers, fruits, and carrion; it may raid farm poultry and damage garden plants. The largest American marsupial, the Virginia opossum is nocturnal and usually terrestrial, but also climbs well and swims strongly. Although not territorial, individuals avoid each other except

when breeding. The female bears up to 21 per litter, yet has only enough teats for 13. The survivors attach to the teats for 48–65 days, leaving the pouch at 70 days.

"PLAYING POSSUM"



When threatened, the Virginia opossum feigns death in an attempt to make predators lose interest. It may lie immobile, partly curled on its side, for up to 6 hours. The mouth and eyes are open, and it does not respond to stimuli, including touch. It may void a foul-smelling fluid from its anus for added effect.



SCRUFFY APPEARANCE

The Virginia opossum's fur varies from gray to red, brown, and black. Long, white-tipped guard hairs with thick underfur make it look unkempt.

Ningauri ridei

Inland ningau



Location C. Australia

Length 2–3 in (5–7.5 cm)

Tail 2–2¼ in (5–7 cm)

Weight $\frac{7}{32}$ – $\frac{7}{16}$ oz (6–12 g)

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



Formally described for science only in 1975, the inland or wongai ningau is a small, fierce, solitary, nocturnal, shrewlike predator of invertebrates, such as beetles, crickets, and spiders, mostly less than $\frac{3}{8}$ in (1 cm) long. It hunts mainly by smell and hearing

in clumps of spinifex (hummock grass), resting by day in thick undergrowth or an old hole dug by a lizard, rodent, or large spider. After an incubation of 13–21 days, 5–8 young ningau attach to the female's teats in her relatively open pouch area for 6 weeks. They are weaned by 13 weeks.

